# COMMON ROUTE

## Chapter 1: A fulfilling school life

**Teacher**
"And with that, homeroom is over. Goodbye."
**Students**
"Goodbye."

I grabbed my bag and pushed my chair back.
Then the classmate in front immediately turned to me.

**Female student**
"Anesaki-san, could you help me with a math question…?"
**Male student**
"Ah, me too, me too."
**Male student**
"I need some help with chemistry too."

Seeing their chance, people began crowding around me.
I hastily stood up and gave them an apologetic smile.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sorry, everyone! I have a student council meeting now, so can we do it another time?"
**Female student**
"Ohhh. I see. Well then, let's do it when you're free!"
**Male student**
"Me too, I'd like some help."
**Male student**
"Maybe we could meet at my house next Sunday then…?"
**Female student**
"Nozomi, you absolutely mustn't go!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Haha… Sorry, see you later."

I laughed it off and quietly slipped away from the group to take a breather.
And then…

**Miho Orikasa**
"I see you're still as popular as ever."

Miho called out to me from behind with a big grin on her face.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Miho… If you saw everything, you might as well have come and helped me."

**Miho Orikasa**
"But I like seeing you flustered, Nozomi. It's fun."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Fun, huh…"
**Miho Orikasa**
"It's like I'm catching a glimpse of a new side to this perfect, model student."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Right."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Although today you managed to run away. Usually you get stuck for at least an hour."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I have a student council meeting today."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Ahhh. …I see."

Miho flashed me a mischievous grin.
Something was telling me I was about to be teased again…

**Miho Orikasa**
"I'm really, rea~ally happy for you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…What?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"I'm still waiting for the day when the rumored couple finally becomes official."

…I refused to give her the satisfaction.
I deliberately cleared my throat and readjusted the grip on my bag.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well then, I gotta go."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Hehe, say 'hello' to Hoshina-senpai for me."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yeah, yeah… See ya."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"*Sigh*..."

Despite myself, a deep sigh escaped my lips.
…No, no, I need to pull myself together.
I took a mirror out of my pocket for a quick appearance check.
After tidying the stray ends of my hair, I straightened my back and walked down the corridor.

**Teacher**
"Ah, goodbye, Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Goodbye."
**Male student**
"Ah, hi, Anesaki-san."

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hello."
**Female student**
"Bye-bye, Nozomi-chan!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Bye-bye!"
**Male student**
"Yo, Vice Prez!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hey."
**Female student**
"Let's hang out again some time soon, Nozomi."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yeah, let's. See ya!"

People I knew well and complete strangers all came up to say hi to me.
…Which makes sense.
I belong to what one might call the "upper tier of the school's social hierarchy."
It's been one and a half years since I enrolled in this school.
I'm always cheerful and polite.
I do it all: maintain top grades, actively participate in the student council, serve as class representative and volunteer in my free time.
Perhaps that's why I'm well-liked by both teachers and students. I'm popular, and my school life couldn't have been going better.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hehe…"

I don't hate being fawned over.
Because it feels good.
I'd much rather be liked by everyone than looked down on.
That's only natural, right?
So this is fine. Everything is going perfectly.
If I keep going like this, I'm sure my future will be just as perfect—

**? ? ?**
"Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Gah?!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah?!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh?! Hoshina-senpai…!"

How did I let that happen?!
Oh no, what should I do? I just let out such an uncouth sound…!

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Oh, um, I'm sorry! I was lost in thought…!"

I hastily straightened my posture and tried to cover it up by speaking in a slightly higher-pitched voice.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Oh, I didn't mean to startle you."

Hoshina-senpai gave me a gentle smile.
…Oh no, my heart couldn't handle this. I realized my face had instantly turned red, and so I quickly averted my gaze.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"S-Senpai, are you on your way to the student council room?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, you too, Anesaki-san?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"That's right."

Naturally, we walked side by side on the way there.
I suddenly noticed people around us giving me envious looks.
Just as Miho said, rumors had spread throughout the school that we were practically a couple.
…In reality, we were nothing more than student council president and vice president.
Feeling surprised, embarrassed… and just a little proud, I walked beside Hoshina-senpai.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"By the way, I think the treasurer and secretary are absent today due to other commitments."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, is that so?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"So that means…"

The student council room fell silent.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…It's just us…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Seems like it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...I see…"

I kept my voice calm, but to be honest…
…I-I have no idea what to do and I'm starting to feel nervous...
N-no, I mean, it's not that uncommon for the two of us to work alone together. It's not a big deal, right? Yeah.

**Mizuho • Nozomi**
"…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Um."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Yes?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Since it's just the two of us…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Y-yes…?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Let's just record our activities and call it a day."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Understood…!"

We both quickly took our seats and started working.
The atmosphere was somewhat awkward.
Ever since people started openly treating us as a couple, Hoshina-senpai seemed to have become more cautious about how he interacted with me.
The same went for me.
When we were alone together like this, I somewhat hesitated to strike up a conversation.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Oh, by the way."

Suddenly Hoshina-senpai stopped what he was doing and looked up at me.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"It's sort of sudden, but it seems like we will have a new transfer student starting tomorrow."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"As soon as tomorrow? That's really sudden."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Apparently they're going to be assigned to your class."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ooh, really?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes. I don't really know what kind of student they are, but I hope you'll be there to help them settle in."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, I'll do my best to help them get used to our school as quickly as possible."

That was exactly the sort of answer everyone expected from the fair and reliable class representative, "Nozomi Anesaki."
I answered like any model student would in my place, and Hoshina-senpai beamed happily at me.

**Mizuho Hoshina**

"Anyone would be safe in your care, Anesaki-san. I think that's why they decided to place the transfer student in your class."

…I couldn't help but feel like they always burdened me with all sorts of troublesome tasks.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…I'll do my best to live up to everyone's expectations."

I replied to him with a smile and my usual answer, then signed the student council diary.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Senpai, I've finished writing in the diary."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Good job. I've pretty much finished my work too. I think we can head home now, even though it's a bit early."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, that sounds good."

# Chapter 2: Going home

Hoshina-senpai locked the student council room door and turned around.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Well then, I'll return the key to the staff room."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"All right…"

**Options:**
(1) I will wait for you.
(2) I will take my leave then.

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## I will wait for you. (Hozumi)

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'll be waiting for you at the entrance then..."

I said it with some hesitation, feeling slightly nervous.
…It's fine. There's nothing strange about it, right?
Whenever the other members are around, we always walk home together.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I'll return the key and be right back."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, I will see you soon."

Watching him walk away left me with a strange feeling of emptiness.

Senpai… isn't interested in me at all. Even though it's just the two of us walking home together, he didn't seem bothered one bit.
I'm probably just an ordinary junior to him.
…It's a bit disappointing.
Well, the reason I can accept that fact relatively easily is probably because I'm hesitant to get any closer to Hoshina-senpai myself.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

I held back a sigh and quickened my pace.
*(Go to "Meeting Shun".)*

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## I will take my leave then.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I will take my leave then."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, good work today. See you tomorrow."
*(Go to "Meeting Shun".)*

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## Meeting Shun

As I headed towards the entrance, I noticed a very familiar figure.
My younger brother.
He was standing idly in front of the shoe lockers, probably waiting for a friend.

**Options:**
(3) Call out to him
(4) Walk past him

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## Call out to him (Shun)

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hi, Shun."

When I called out to him, Shun flinched and turned around.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Sis? Didn't you have a student council meeting?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm done for today. Are you heading home now, Shun?"
**Shun Anesaki**

"Ah… yeah. …What about you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Me too."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hmm…"

It looked like Shun wanted to say something.
As I silently waited for him to continue, a voice called out from nearby.

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*If you picked "I will wait for you."*
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, Hoshina-senpai. You were quick."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes. Shall we head home?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Of course. See you later, Shun."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Uh-huh."
*(Go to "Going home with Senpai")*

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*If you picked "I will take my leave then."*
**Male student**
"Shun!"
**Male student**
"Let's head home."

These were probably Shun's friends.
I took a small step back from him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"See you later."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Huh? Ah, yeah."

I gave Shun a small wave and turned away.
Then I heard a lively conversation behind me.

**Male student**
"That was your sister, wasn't it?"
**Male student**
"She's really pretty."
**Male student**
"You should introduce me to her."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Shuddup."

His blunt response made the corners of my mouth curl upward involuntarily.
I never get tired of hearing compliments.
I left the entrance hall with a slight grin on my face.
*(Go to the next chapter)*

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## Walk past him

*If you picked "I will wait for you."*
I couldn't think of anything to say to him, so I just headed straight to my shoe locker.
As I leisurely put on my shoes, Hoshina-senpai appeared before me, slightly out of breath.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Sorry I kept you waiting, Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, you were quick."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah, I'm glad. Shall we head home?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes."

**Shun • Nozomi**
"Ah."

As soon as we stepped outside, we ran into Shun.

**Male student**
"Ah, President Hoshina, Vice President Anesaki."
**Male student.**
"Goodbye!"

Two male students who were with Shun approached us with grins on their faces.

**Mizuho • Nozomi**
"Goodbye."

When my voice overlapped with Senpai's, the two boys whistled.

**Male student**
"Like a married couple."
**Male student**
"You're perfectly in sync."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Huh…?"

…Ugh, I hate this. They're making things awkward for Hoshina-senpai…
It's one thing when people spread rumors behind our backs, but when they act like this right in front of us, I never know how to respond. I wish they'd stop.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Hey, let's go. If we don't hurry, that clerk's shift will be over before we even get there."
**Male student**
"Woah, that would suck. We gotta go."

The boys ran off in a hurry.
As Shun was about to follow suit, I shot him a quick glance.
It was my way of saying, "Thanks. You saved me."

**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

Shun paused for a moment, then suddenly turned away and ran off.
*(Go to "Going home with Senpai")*

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*If you picked "I will take my leave then."*
I couldn't think of anything to say to him, so I just left the entrance hall.
*(Go to the next chapter)*

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# Going home with Senpai

*Image:*
Blue sign: Sasajiin High School - 1 km from here
Green sign: School zone

After leaving the school gates, I couldn't think of anything to say to Hoshina-senpai for a while.
As I searched for a topic to make small talk about, Senpai suddenly spoke up as though he had just remembered something.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"By the way, that first-year from earlier… wasn't that your younger brother, Anesaki-san?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"It was. His name is Shun."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I hear his name come up every now and then. The teachers think highly of him, and I think he's popular in his class too."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, is that so?"

That was the first time I'd heard of it.
But I didn't find it surprising.
Shun has always been the popular type.
...His grades don't seem to be very good, though.

**Mizuho Hoshina**

"Do you two get along?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hmm, well… I'd say we do."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I see. I mean, who wouldn't get along with a sister like you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ahaha…"

I could feel my face getting stiff…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"If I remember correctly... you have a younger brother too, right, Hoshina-senpai?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, that's right."

Hoshina-senpai's brother, huh…
I don't know anything about him, but I bet he's incredibly handsome, just like Senpai.
He's probably very intelligent too. And calm and kind as well.
Ahh… What a treat! Two handsome, noble brothers…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Are you two close?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah… well… I wouldn't say that…"

Huh. That was an unexpected answer.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You don't get along?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hmm... Yes, I can't really say we do."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Really…? That's surprising."

With his personality, it's hard to imagine him not getting along with his siblings.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"We used to be pretty close, but now I feel like there's some distance between us…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Isn't that just how it is as you get older? It's pretty rare for siblings to stay as close as they were when they were kids."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...I guess you're right. Still, I envy how close you and your brother are."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...We weren't exactly close in the past, either."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Huh? Really?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Yes."

That change was actually fairly recent.
It's only been about two years since we developed the kind of relationship we have now.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Was there something that brought you closer?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well…"

If I went into that, I'd have to remember a lot of unpleasant things too.
I stopped myself from dwelling on the past and tilted my head uncertainly.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hmm... I wonder… I don't remember clearly. I think it was something simple…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah… I see."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I hope you and your brother can become close again."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Thanks. I'll see what I can do."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Okay."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Ah! Anesaki-san, watch out!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh?"

Hoshina-senpai suddenly grabbed my hand.
A car sped past right beside me an instant later.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"That was close. That driver didn't even notice us."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I-I'm so sorry. I wasn't paying attention…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I'm also sorry for grabbing you so suddenly."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"N-no, don't worry about it... And thank you..."

More importantly…
We're standing way too close…!
And on top of that, we're still holding hands.
Ugh… What should I do? If I keep thinking about it, my hands are going to get sweaty…
As I hurriedly tried to pull away,
a vibrating sound suddenly rang out.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Sorry, give me a second."

Senpai stepped away from me, took his phone out of his bag, and held it to his ear.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hello…? Uh, do you need it right now?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah... Okay, I understand."

…Who is he talking with? A friend, perhaps?
Senpai seems to be having fun... or rather, he looks happy.
He is always cheerful, but this might be the first time I've seen him look so carefree.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, see you later."

With a cheerful expression still on his face, Senpai hung up and turned back to me.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Anesaki-san, I have something to take care of, so I'll head this way."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, okay, I understand."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"It's still light out, but be careful on your way home."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Of course. Goodbye."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"See you tomorrow."

Senpai smiled and waved before walking off in a different direction from our usual route home. I wondered who he was going to meet.
Must be nice… I'm a little jealous of whoever that person is.
At school I get to talk to him all the time, but the moment we step outside, our relationship suddenly feels distant.
Even though the students treat us like a couple, the truth is that we barely interact outside of the school setting.
…Well, I guess that's just how it is.
There was a void in my chest, though I wouldn't call it sadness.
I adjusted the strap on my shoulder and headed down a different road.

# Chapter 3: Into the world of dreams

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm home."

Even though I said it, I knew no one would answer.
My parents have been working overseas for about six months now. Currently, only my younger brother Shun and I are living in this house.
Shun often takes long detours with his friends, so he probably won't be back for a while.
I'm all alone.
No one is watching me. No one will interrupt me.
And that means…

**Wald**
"Nozomi... There's something I've been meaning to tell you for a very long time."
**Nozomi**
"Huh…? What could it be…?"
**Wald**
"I love you."
**Nozomi**
"...What?"
**Wald**
"I love you. I have feelings for you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Kyaaa!!! I also love youuu!!!"

*Image:*
Top shelf book: Fashion for girls
Bottom left book: Second-Year Maths
Bottom right book: The Big Dictionary

I instinctively tossed my game console aside.
I flopped around on the bed a few times before burying my face in my pillow.
…Oh no, I can't stop grinning.
Calm down. Calm down, now.
We have just started the confession scene. If that's enough to get me this worked up, I might faint by the end.
I took a deep breath and picked up the game console again.
And then I smirked and eagerly pressed the button.

**Wald**
"I've only ever had eyes for you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Me too!"
**Wald**
"I want to hear your answer."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I already know…!"
**Wald**
"Will you marry me?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes!!! Of course!!!"
**Wald**

"I'm so glad… May I touch you…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes!!! Go ahead!!!"
**Wald**
"Nozomi…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald…"

Lord Wald moved his hand to touch my cheek.
His face slowly drew closer.
And then…

**? ? ?**
"Sis."
……
……
…Huh?

# Chapter 4: Forced awakening

The scenery had suddenly changed.
Just a moment ago I was in a gorgeous palace, but now my own room, so familiar and ordinary, stretched out before me.
And when I looked up, I saw my younger brother standing beside my bed and staring down at me.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun…?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh… Wait a minute. Why are you here?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Don't you usually come home later?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"We didn't do much—just quickly stopped by the convenience store."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Really?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Really."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You could've knocked, you know."
**Shun Anesaki**
"I did. You even said, 'Yes, go ahead,' when I asked if I could come in."
**Shun • Nozomi**

"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I was talking with Lord Wald, not you!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"How was I supposed to know?!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Aww…"

I dropped the game console I was holding.
Shun's sudden appearance completely killed the mood.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…You are the worst. Seriously, it's such a letdown. The scene was just getting good…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"What, are you blaming me?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I sure am. Why would you barge in when I was about to kiss Lord Wald?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Pfft. 'Kiss Lord Wald,' huh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...What's with that face? Are you mocking me?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"No, not at all."

I noticed the corners of Shun's lips twitching as he said that.
He is soo annoying.

**Shun Anesaki**
"If you want to keep going at it, you should probably change. Your uniform is already all wrinkled up."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh? Ah!"

Oh no. The pleats in my skirt are coming loose.
I hastily got up and reached for the clasp on my skirt.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Get out, Shun, I need to change."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah, okay, got it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"By the way, did you need anything?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Well, I was wondering what we should have for dinner tonight."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"What, just that?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yep."

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Man… To think that something so trivial ruined my sweet ending with Lord Wald…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"There she goes with 'Lord Wald' again."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shut up. You have a problem with that?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"No. It's just… I don't think anyone would ever guess you were like this, Sis."

He muttered, lost in thought. I couldn't argue with that.
That was true.
At school, I, Nozomi Anesaki, was known as "the brilliant, beautiful, flawless student council vice president," but in reality, I was just an otaku who loved anime and games (especially otome games).
The only person who knew that was standing right in front of me.
No one else did. I'd been keeping it a secret even from my best friend, Miho.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Whatever. I'm keeping it well-hidden at school."
**Shun Anesaki**
"But is that really fine? How long can you keep this up?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You mean my otaku hobbies?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"No, what I meant is how long are you gonna keep on hiding it?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"My whole life."
**Shun Anesaki**
"You're joking, right? That's impossible."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Why not? No one's noticed so far. I'll just keep going like this forever."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...No… I mean… What about…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"What about what?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"...What about when you get a boyfriend, for example?"

He asked quietly. I snorted at his words.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Boyfriend? As in, three-dimensional?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, no, no, no, not happening."

Don't make me laugh.

A 3D boyfriend? Is he being serious?

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Real men are garbage with no moe* appeal."
*Having endearing traits that evoke strong affection; a term strongly associated with otaku culture.
**Shun Anesaki**
"H-hey."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"They're no good. I have never met anyone who came even close to Lord Wald."
**Shun Anesaki**
"What was it again? Your Lord Wald is a prince of some country, right?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"He has a lean, muscular build and stands 181 cm tall while weighing 67 kg. His hobbies are horseback riding and fencing, and his skills in these are unmatched."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"And he has a frail little sister... [omitted] ...and with a tolerance as vast as the universe, he continues to love me devotedly and faithfully—a super-ultra-handsome blond, blue-eyed dreamboat!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Amazing. You didn't stutter even once."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"So? What's your opinion? Is there  a n y  m a n  who could surpass Lord Wald?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Why are you defending him this seriously…? Anyway, such people don't exist in real life. They're only in the realm of 2D."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"That's right. You get it. Only 2D can beat 2D."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Hm, but what about him?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Him?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Prez."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Ahhh... I see…"

That was a good one.
Hoshina-senpai might indeed be an exception.
It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that Senpai is almost a 2D character. You could say he's a 2.1D guy.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yeah, Hoshina-senpai would be a good pick."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Yeah, right."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"He is like a real prince…"

Senpai's kind smile came to mind. He had an incredible princely aura.
When I looked at him, I felt the same excitement and fondness as when I saw Lord Wald's smiling portrait.

**Shun Anesaki**
"...So, what would you do if you ended up dating him?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh… Me and Hoshina-senpai…? Dating…?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Not happening."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Why? It's very likely to happen. In fact, at school, everyone talks about you two as if you're already a couple."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"True... But we aren't actually dating..."

No matter how much the people at school tried to play matchmaker for us, Hoshina-senpai and I would always be merely president and vice president.
Senpai was kind to me, but he was like that with everyone. I could tell he didn't treat me differently.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I think he only sees me as a diligent junior."
**Shun Anesaki**
"What makes you think so?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"My experience from playing 200 otome games."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Otome games, huh."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I can tell. I didn't raise any flags for his route."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Don't say it with such a smug face. …Never mind Prez, how do you feel?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Me?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, what do you think of him?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"He is a 2.1D guy."
**Shun Anesaki**
"No, like, do you want to date him or anything?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Dating Hoshina-senpai…"

If we were together…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...It would be wonderful."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...But I can't."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Why?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I don't think Hoshina-senpai's tolerance is as vast as the universe."

No matter how kind Hoshina-senpai may be,
I don't think he will accept an otaku.
I simply don't have the courage to reveal my true self.
If I could hide all my flaws and continue being "Nozomi Anesaki" like I do at school, maybe it would even be possible to date him.
But I don't want to be in a relationship with a man that badly.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"My only boyfriend is Lord Wald."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Mmm... Well, if you're okay with this, then I guess it's fine..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Okay, I need to change now."
**Shun Anesaki**
" 'Kay, okay, I'm leaving."

I called out to Shun as he was about to leave.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hm?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I won't cause you any trouble, so don't worry."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

Shun opened his mouth for a moment, but in the end left the room without saying anything.
……
That's right. I won't cause any trouble for Shun.
I intend to continue playing the role of "the brilliant, beautiful, flawless student council vice president" at school.
I'm sure I won't change my attitude even after graduating.
Shun said it was impossible, but I'm confident I can keep up the act.
Because I probably won't ever be in a relationship with anyone.

# Chapter 5: I overslept

**Wald**
"Nozomi…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, Lord Wald…?"
**Wald**
"Wake up. It's already morning."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No… I'm still sleepy..."
**Wald**
"Hahaha, you're being so selfish, Nozomi."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Because it feels so good to be in your arms, Lord Wald…"
**Wald**
"Wow. Gross."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh."

My mind snapped awake. A white ceiling filled my vision,
and within that frame stood Shun, peering down at me.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Wake up. You'll be late."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh, what?! What time is it now?!"

Usually, I wake up earlier than Shun.
Because he insisted on sleeping until the last minute, waking him up had become part of my daily routine.
If Shun was already awake, that meant…

**Shun Anesaki**
"8 am."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
" ! ! ! "

Panic overtook me, and I sprang to my feet with a silent cry.
Students must arrive at school by 8:30 AM.
It takes about 15 minutes to run from my house to school. Which means…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I only have 15 minutes left to get ready?!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I guess so."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I can't do it!!! This is impossible! Why didn't you wake me up sooner?!"

**Shun Anesaki**
"Well, I woke up just a moment ago myself."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Idiot!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Well, why did you oversleep then?!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yesterday I got so engrossed in playing games that I stayed up until late at night..."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Idiot..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"There is no time for this right now! We have to hurry!!!"

I immediately started getting changed.
Shun hurried towards the exit of the room.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Okay, I'll go to school first."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Whaaat?! Wait a minute! What are you talking about?!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh, what's wrong?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I can't go before you do an outfit check. So you gotta wait for me!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Honestly, I've thought for the longest time that these checks are completely unnecessary."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You thought wrong! Just wait a bit! I'll change right away!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah… Fine, okay…"

Shun shook his head and walked out of the room.
Meanwhile, I hurriedly removed my loungewear and changed into my school uniform.
I stomped into the bathroom and brushed my teeth so hard I thought I was going to give myself tendinitis.
I don't have time to do a morning face mask... Damn it...
I guess I'll just use a slightly more expensive toner.
First, I took care of my face, then I moved on to my hair.
I took a good long look at myself in the mirror…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Noooo!!!"

I let out a terrified cry.

**Shun Anesaki**
"What happened?!"

Shun rushed over to me with a worried look on his face.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I have dark circles under my eyes!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Huh…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"And as if that wasn't bad enough, I've got bedhead too…! It will be a pain to deal with!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah... I see..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun, what should I do? Help me!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Argh, come on, just give me the comb already."

I quickly handed the comb to him.
Shun started blow-drying my hair while muttering something under his breath.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Honestly… It's not as bad as you think. There was no reason to panic like that."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Absolutely not! Nozomi Anesaki is famous for her flawlessly straight hair, perfectly smooth all the way to the tips."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, right."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hey... Do you think these dark circles are obvious? I used concealer, but does it actually do a good job of hiding them?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hey, don't just give me a half-baked answer. You didn't even look at me properly, did you?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I did, I did. Here, all done."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wow, that was quick. Did you deal with my bedhead?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I did, I did."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hey, Shun, since you're already doing my hair, tie it into twintails too!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Really, you're making me do that too?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"It's 'cause you're better at this kind of thing."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Oh, man…"

With a slight pout, Shun began tying my hair.

His movements were as precise as ever, which was hardly surprising considering his goal of becoming a hairstylist.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Yep, all good."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wow, that was fast! We still have 5 minutes to spare!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hurry up and get your stuff ready."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Okay! I'll be right back."
**Shun Anesaki**
" 'Kay, okay."

I went back to my room and put the things I needed for the day into my bag.
A top student can't be forgetting their school items.
After carefully checking my school supplies, I picked up my bag and left the room.
When I made my way to the entrance, I found Shun waiting there with his own bag.

**Shun Anesaki**
"You got everything?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yep, all good."
**Shun Anesaki**
"All right, then we can head out."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wait… you haven't done my outfit check yet!"

I quickly straightened my posture and stood right in front of Shun, waiting for his judgment.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well? Do I look good?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"And perfect?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, perfect."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"And cute?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, cute."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"And poop?"

**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, poop… Oh."

Shun's expression immediately screamed, "I messed up."
I grabbed his face with both hands and forced him to look at me.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Look. At. Me. Carefully."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah, wai…"

At such a close distance, I could clearly see Shun's face turning just a little red.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Uh… Why are you blushing…?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"! Shut up. You're too close."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well, that reaction is all the proof I need that I'm cute today too."

I released his face and slowly put on my shoes.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well then, I'm off!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Excuse me?! I was waiting for you this whole time, and that's how you thank me?!"

*Image:*
Sign on the right: Fast and cheap!
15-minute walk; 1 km east

I rushed out of the house, ignoring his complaints.
Shun caught up almost right away and walked beside me.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah, damn it… I shouldn't have waited for you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You didn't have the option to say no."
**Shun Anesaki**
"What a tyrant…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Thank you for doing it though."

I felt like I should at least express my gratitude. I genuinely appreciated it.

**Shun Anesaki**
"...Whatever."

# Chapter 6: Light novel boy

We kept running without slowing down until the school gate finally came into view.
Shun exhaled and slowed his pace.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Why are we running…? We have plenty of time left."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Because showing up to school at the very last minute is uncool."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Is that so? Ah, hey, Sis! Watch out!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hu-uh?"
**Nozomi • ? ? ?**
"Guh?!"

A jolt ran through my body.
My vision blurred, and everything faded to black. Before I realized what had happened, I was sitting on the ground.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ouch, ouch, ouch…"

As I slowly opened my eyes, I saw a male student crouched before me.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, I'm so sorry! Are you okay?!"

I hurriedly helped the boy to his feet.
The student kept his head lowered, hiding most of his face. Slowly, he looked up.

**? ? ?**
"Ah. Yes, I'm fine."

It was a student I'd never seen before. His long bangs obscured most of his features.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Are you hurt anywhere...?"
**? ? ?**
"I'm not sure. More importantly… Are you all right?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm totally fine."
**? ? ?**
"I see. That's great."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hey, we'd better get going. We're almost out of time."

Shun glanced up at the clock tower. The bell was due to ring in three minutes.
As I was about to move along, I noticed something lying on the ground.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Excuse me…"

I almost asked, "Is this yours?" but stopped myself.

*Image:*
"The Childhood Friend and the Class Representative's Relationship" by Moeo Mainichi (lit. "Moeman Everyday")

The object on the ground was a novel.
Its dust jacket had slipped off, exposing the cover beneath.
A pink-haired girl on the cover stared back at me, sticking out her tongue.
It was the kind of light novel cover that went all-in on moe appeal.

**? ? ?**
"Ah..."

The male student also noticed the dropped item and awkwardly froze in place.

**Options:**
(1) Pretend not to notice
(2) Pick it up

---

## Pretend not to notice

I pretended not to notice, brushed the dirt from my uniform, and stood up.
The boy quickly put the novel back in his bag, then glanced at me as if trying to gauge my reaction.
…Yeah, I probably shouldn't mention it.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um... I'm really sorry for bumping into you."
**? ? ?**
"N-no, please don't worry about it..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well then... excuse me."
**? ? ?**
"...Right."
*(Go to "Going to class")*

---

## Pick it up (Ayumu)

I slipped the dust jacket back into place without a second thought.
Then, as though nothing unusual had happened, I handed the novel to him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Here you go."
**? ? ?**
"Ah… Um… thank you very much."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No worries. Goodbye."
*(Go to "Going to class")*

---

## Going to class

I gave him a slight bow and passed through the gate.
Shun, who had been waiting nearby, walked over with a smirk on his face.

**Shun Anesaki**
"I think you'd get along with that guy. Don't you agree?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Don't be ridiculous."
**Shun Anesaki**
"I mean, there is no harm in making a new friend."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Not happening. Besides, he is in a different class, so I'll probably never see him again."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hmm, that's a shame."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Forget that—we only have two minutes left!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Ah, crap!"

We sprinted towards the entrance.
By the time I changed into my indoor shoes, the boy from earlier had completely slipped my mind.

# Chapter 7: Transfer student

When I arrived at the classroom, everyone immediately turned their attention to me.

**Male student**
"Anesaki-san arrived!"
**Male student**
"Ahh. Thank goodness. I was starting to think school had been canceled."
**Female student**

"Nozomi, good mooorning!!"
**Female student**
"I was worried that something happened to you!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ahaha, good morning."

It's weird to say that about myself, but to be honest, the popularity of "Nozomi Anesaki" always amazes me. It's so intense that it frightens me sometimes.
Once I greeted everyone back and took my seat, Miho turned to me from the desk next to mine.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Morning. You're late."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Good morning. I overslept a little."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Oh, that's a surprise. I guess even top students have their off days."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Apparently."
**Miho Orikasa**
"...Huh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hm?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Did you get enough sleep?"

Miho narrowed her eyes and stared at me intently.
…Wow, she noticed it right away, even though I covered it up with concealer.
Women really do have sharp eyes. …Or maybe Shun simply wasn't looking very carefully.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I was up pretty late last night…"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Studying?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um… Yeah, sort of."

There was no way I could admit I spent the night flirting with Lord Wald.

**Miho Orikasa**
"You should drop that habit. Lack of sleep is terrible for your skin."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um… I mean, are my dark circles that noticeable?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Hm? Not really. Just a little."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Do I look weird?"
**Miho Orikasa**

"Not at all."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I see..."

I felt a slight sense of relief, but I was still a little unsettled.
Ever since I began playing this role, I couldn't stop worrying about how others perceived me.
I knew I was overly self-conscious. Maybe even narcissistic.
I didn't like that about myself.
But I couldn't stop wanting to look perfect to others at all times.
The bell rang, and a little while later, the teacher entered the room.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Stand up, bow, sit down."

After I finished my routine duties as class representative, the teacher stood at the front of the classroom, looking around with an unusually excited expression.

**Teacher**
"I have an important announcement today."

Oh, that's right, a transfer student is joining our class today.

**Teacher**
"Please go ahead, Kuraguchi-kun."

The teacher called out to someone at the door.
The moment I saw the student who entered the classroom...
I froze in place.

**Teacher**
"This is a little sudden, but a transfer student will be joining this class starting today."

A wave of whispers spread through the classroom. Despite everything happening around me, I remained motionless.
The light novel guy from earlier... was actually a transfer student?

**Teacher**
"Kuraguchi-kun, please introduce yourself."
**Kuraguchi**
"Okay."

Prompted by the teacher, the transfer student began writing on the blackboard.
After neatly writing his name in beautiful handwriting, he turned towards us and bowed.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"My name is Ayumu Kuraguchi… Nice to meet you."

The classroom buzzed with its usual chatter. I, however, couldn't move or speak.

…To be more precise, hearing his name left me frozen once more.
Wait a second. What did he just say?
"Ayumu Kuraguchi"?
I took another look at what was written on the blackboard.
The name "Ayumu Kuraguchi" was displayed across the blackboard in clear, neat handwriting.
Ayumu Kuraguchi.
Ayumu. Ayumu…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ayumu-kun…?"

My quietly murmured words blended into the noise of the classroom and faded away unnoticed.
My gaze remained fixed on the transfer student standing before the blackboard.
And on his features, marked by a subtle uneasiness and downcast eyes.
Ah, now I'm certain. It's him.
He looked so much more mature than I remembered that I didn't even recognize him.
But there was no mistaking it. He was Ayumu Kuraguchi-kun, someone I had once been good friends with.

**Teacher**
"So, Kuraguchi-kun, where should I seat you…"

The teacher turned in my direction.
I knew it would happen, but I still couldn't help but look away.

**Teacher**
"You'll be sitting next to Anesaki-san. She's also on the Student Council, so feel free to ask her if you have any questions."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Ah. Okay."

Our eyes met. His expression changed to one of surprise.
He must have remembered our earlier encounter.
But surely Ayumu-kun hadn't realized who I was.
After all, compared to him, I'd changed dramatically since middle school.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"

Ayumu-kun silently sat down in the seat next to me.
"Nozomi Anesaki, the fair and dependable class representative," should be exchanging a greeting or two here.
...That was what I had to do.
I put on my usual friendly smile and turned toward him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Um… I'm sorry about earlier. And nice to meet you."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Oh, yeah. Likewise. Um..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm Nozomi Anesaki."

I hesitated for a moment, but decided to introduce myself anyway.
…It should be fine. My surname changed after middle school. Surely he wouldn't recognize me from just my first name alone.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Anesaki-san... Nice to meet you."

Just as I expected, there was no sign of recognition in his expression as he extended his hand.
I responded with a smile, feeling relieved.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yeah, nice to meet you, Ayumu-kun."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"

Ayumu-kun suddenly stopped moving.
…? Did I say something weird...?
"Yeah, nice to meet you, Ayumu-kun."
…Everything seems normal to me.
.....
.....
Wait. Did I just call him by his first name?
That slipped out naturally, but that's not how you address someone you've just met.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, I mean… Kuraguchi-kun."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"

I tried correcting myself, but the awkwardness remained.
Ayumu—or rather, Kuraguchi-kun—stared at me without blinking even once.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Nozomi-chan…?"

The bell rang, signaling the beginning of class.

I immediately turned away and began preparing for class with the most serious expression I could manage.
I could feel his gaze from behind me… For now, I'll pretend not to notice.
Despite desperately trying to maintain a calm demeanor, an unpleasant sweat ran down my spine.
Did he figure it out…?
No... Impossible… There is no way he could.
Everything is different now compared to when I was in middle school.
The only thing that hasn't changed is my otaku side.
...Kuraguchi-kun probably hasn't changed much in that regard either.
He had a light novel with him, so I'm sure he is still immersed in subculture.
A sense of nostalgia and familiarity washed over me. That was exactly why I couldn't interact with him like I used to.
I felt bad for him, but I valued the place I'd built for myself here more than any past connection.
The rest of the class passed without incident.
While I was gathering my supplies, I glanced sideways to check on Kuraguchi-kun.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"

I noticed Kuraguchi-kun glance in my direction as he gathered his textbooks.
I abruptly spun my body around in my chair, turning my back to him.
To cover up how awkward my movements were, I started talking to Miho, who was sitting next to me.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Miho, did you do your homework for today's English class?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Noope. I completely forgot about it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Then let's hope you don't get called on."
**Miho Orikasa**
"But you will help me out, right?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Okay, fine."
**Miho Orikasa**
"By the way..."

Miho lowered her voice and glanced behind me.

**Miho Orikasa**
"I was really surprised by the transfer student."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Uh… Ah... Yeah, you're right. It was pretty sudden."
**Miho Orikasa**
"But Nozomi, did you notice?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Noticed what?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"That guy kept looking at you during class."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh…?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Maybe he has a cruuush on you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, there is no way."

I could deny it with absolute confidence. Kuraguchi-kun wasn't looking at me like that.
…But it seems like he's caught on. I don't want any trouble, so all I can do is keep pretending not to know him.

**Miho Orikasa**
"You know, I think that guy…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hm?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"He is an otaku, isn't he?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

I nearly made a strange noise.
"Otaku."
Just hearing that word from someone else's mouth felt like a direct attack.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"U-uh… Y-you think?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Mm-hmm. He has that kind of air around him..."

I wonder what it smells like... I wonder if I smell like that too.
…No, no, I'm fine. I should only smell like flowers. I'm careful about the shampoo and body cream I use.

**Miho Orikasa**
"I hope he can fit in with our class."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...I agree."

I gave an awkward nod in response to Miho's comment, picking up on the implication behind her words.
Our class is filled with students who would generally be considered popular and "socially successful."
Many of them look down on otaku culture, and it's not uncommon to hear disparaging comments about people who are into that sort of thing.

Fortunately or unfortunately, nearly everyone in the class shares that mindset, which is why the classroom is so lively, friendly, and harmonious.
For someone who doesn't fit in, however, it would probably feel like an incredibly uncomfortable place to be.
I've managed to survive by constantly putting on an act, but the truth is that maintaining that facade quietly wears me down day after day.
If Kuraguchi-kun is still the same person he was back then, he'll likely end up feeling just as out of place as I do.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Try to get along with him, Miss Class Rep."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Haha…"

I responded to Miho's teasing with a wry smile.
...As if. The last thing I wanted was to get involved with him.
I felt so strongly about it that I stubbornly kept my back turned toward Kuraguchi-kun until the bell for the next class finally rang.

# Chapter 8: Lunch

Morning classes finally ended.
Throughout the lessons, I kept my eyes fixed on my notebook and the blackboard. During breaks, I either talked with Miho or wandered away from my seat, deliberately avoiding eye contact with Kuraguchi-kun.
If I can keep this up, I should be able to stay away from him.
…Or so I thought.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Excuse me."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

…It's like he's setting up a route flag.
I'll just ignore it for now. I pretended not to hear him and began preparing for lunch.
Come to think of it, I overslept today, so I couldn't prepare my lunch box.
I guess I'll just go buy something at the school store.
Let's see, wallet, wallet…

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"...Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

This is bad… He called me by name... At this point, completely ignoring him would make me feel really guilty.

But still… Hmm… What should I do?

**Options:**
(1) Respond
(2) Pretend not to hear him

---

# Respond (Ayumu)

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes? What is it?"

Forcing a smile, I turned to face Kuraguchi-kun.
The moment I did, his face lit up with joy.
Oh no... I hope he doesn't misunderstand. I have no intention of letting us become any closer than we need to be.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Um... I didn't bring my lunch today..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I see."
**Ayumi Kuraguchi**
"So... I was hoping you could tell me where the cafeteria and school store are..."
**Nozomi Anezaki**
"...Leave the classroom and go straight left. Turn right at the end of the hallway, take the stairs down, turn left immediately, continue straight, then..."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"… ? ? ?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Come on, Nozomi, how is a transfer student supposed to understand that from directions alone?"

Miho cut in, shaking her head in disbelief.
I begrudgingly fetched a pen and a sheet of loose-leaf paper, then began drawing a map of the route to the cafeteria.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Wow... that's an incredibly detailed map... Wouldn't it have been easier to just lead him to the cafeteria though...?"

Ignoring Miho's perfectly valid point, I handed the finished map to Kuraguchi-kun.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"This is the classroom. Do you recognize it?"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Um... Oh, yeah, I can read it. Thank you for this very detailed map."

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You're welcome."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"...Well then, I'm off."
**Nozom Anesaki**
"Take care."

Kuraguchi-kun left the classroom.
Watching him leave, I let out a sigh of relief. I was glad we'd kept the conversation to a minimum.
I still need to buy myself lunch, but... I probably shouldn't head there just yet. I don't want to risk running into him.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Huh? Nozomi, where is your lunch?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I didn't bring it today."
**Miho Orikasa**
"So are you gonna buy one?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yeah, that was the plan."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Then you could've just gone with the transfer student earlier."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um…"
**Miho Orikasa**
"I suppose you were worried he'd get the wrong impression if you got too friendly with him. "
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Haha…"

Miho's statement, which hit the mark in more ways than one, left me with no choice but to give an ambiguous smile.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Oh, by the way. I brought bread in addition to my lunch today, so would you like some?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh, really?"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Mm, of course."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Thank you."

While I was having lunch with Miho, Kuraguchi-kun eventually made his way back to the classroom.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Um... thank you. I was able to find the school store without getting lost."
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"You're welcome."

After giving that brief reply, I turned my attention back to Miho.
Perhaps he picked up on the mood, because Kuraguchi-kun didn't try to continue the conversation. He simply returned to his seat and silently sat down.
No one seemed particularly interested in him. Everyone was already gathered in their own groups, chatting and enjoying their lunch as usual.
It's unfortunate, but... this is reality, isn't it...? Only handsome transfer students in two-dimensional worlds get instantly surrounded and adored.
As I watched Kuraguchi-kun quietly eat his bread by himself, a memory from my past suddenly came back to me.
Even though I felt a faint bitterness welling up inside, I still couldn't bring myself to speak to him.
*(Go to the next chapter)*

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## Pretend not to hear him

I really don't want to talk about the past... I have no choice but to ignore him. Sorry, Kuraguchi-kun...
I pretended not to hear him and started rummaging through my bag.
…Huh? Where's my wallet?
I checked both the outer and inner pockets, but it was nowhere to be found.

**Miho Orikasa**
"Nozomi, what's wrong?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I think I forgot my wallet."
**Miho Orikasa**
"Huh, really? But where is your lunch box?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I didn't bring one today, so I was planning to buy something from the school store…"
**Miho Orikasa**
"Do you want to borrow some money?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hmm…"

**Options:**
(2) Accept
(3) Decline

---

## Accept (Hozumi)

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, thank you, I will give it back next time."
**Miho Orikasa**

"Okay."

I borrowed money from Miho and headed to the store.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"!"

As I walked down the corridor, a bright light ahead suddenly blinded me.

**Female student**
"Hello, President Hoshina!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hello."
**Female student**
"Senpaiii. Hellooo!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hello."

Hoshina-senpai smiled warmly at everyone around him as he walked by.
His princely aura was as overwhelming as ever.
Honestly, it was shining so brightly that it blinded me.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah, Anesaki-san, hello."

Before I could even react, he was already standing right in front of me, wearing that flawless smile of his.
If this were an otome game, I'm sure there would be a CG here. Actually, I think Hoshina-senpai's route ought to have a cg for every time he smiles.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Anesaki-san?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah."

Crap. My imagination has gone wild again.
I hastily returned a smile to Hoshina-senpai.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hello, Senpai. Are you about to have lunch?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, I was thinking I'd eat in the student council room today."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, do you have work to do?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, it's nothing major. I just need to organize some paperwork."

Hoshina-senpai's definition of "nothing major" should be taken with a grain of salt.

His competence was often used against him. Teachers gave him an enormous amount of work.
But Hoshina-senpai handled all of it with a smile like a real prince.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um... Do you need my help?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, I would appreciate it... But Anesaki-san, you haven't eaten yet, have you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, I was just about to."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"If you help me, you won't have much time to eat. Are you okay with that?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Don't worry, it's fine. I'll just quickly head to the school store and be right back."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Huh? Anesaki-san, you didn't bring your lunch?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, yes. I overslept this morning…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Oh, who would have thought that even Anesaki-san could oversleep."

Ugh... I messed up. I should have told him a cute lie.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hmm... I see... Then…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...? Is something on your mind, Senpai?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Well… you see, I actually brought two lunch boxes with me today…"

Senpai smiled bashfully, as if he was hesitant to say it.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Would you like to have one of them, Anesaki-san…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh."

I...? I'm going to... eat Hoshina-senpai's homemade lunch...?

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"A lunch box...?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Your lunch box...?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes."
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"...Wait, was it made by you, Senpai?!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah… Yes, sort of…"

He shyly averted his eyes. Omg, he is so feminine...!
He is so moe...!

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Would you rather not?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'll thoroughly enjoy it."

I answered without a moment's hesitation.
I mean, Hoshina-senpai made it himself! It's the Prince's own cooking, no less.

**Wald**
"I made this meal just for you. Will you have it?"

That's what it looks like, you know?
What girl could possibly say no to that?
I hit the "I'll gladly accept" option over and over with everything I've got.
Why Senpai brought two bento boxes in the first place was a mystery, but either way, this was my lucky break.
I decided to accept his kind offer and headed to the student council room with him.
We arrived at the student council room, and I quickly took a seat opposite Senpai.
Come to think of it, I've never eaten with Senpai one-on-one like this before.
Slightly tense over this unexpected lunch date, I watched as Senpai placed two lunch boxes on the table in front of me. Both were simple lunch boxes with a distinctly masculine feel.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Enjoy."

He handed one of the boxes to me. Only now did I start wondering whether it was really appropriate for me to accept an entire lunch box like this.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...U-um... Is this really okay? Are you sure?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"It is, it is. Don't be shy."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Senpai, you weren't planning on eating both lunch boxes yourself, were you...?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hahaha, I'm not that much of a glutton."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm curious, why do you have two then...?"

Everything suddenly clicked for me while I was saying that.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Did you perhaps make one for your younger brother?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"No, that's not why. He always buys his own lunch."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh... I thought you were making a bunch of them at once, Senpai."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I did suggest that, but he refused, saying it would be embarrassing."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Embarrassing, huh?"

Now that I think about it, Shun also seemed a bit embarrassed when I first started making lunch boxes for him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"That's kind of cute."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Uh... Cute...? Well... I'm not sure about that…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"It's probably because he's at that sensitive age."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Sensitive age...? Pfft, ahaha! Yes, maybe you're right."

He was laughing so hard that he had to hold his stomach.
I don't really get what was so funny about that, but I'm happy I made him laugh.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um... so it's okay if I take it?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, in fact, that would help me out."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well then... I'll gladly accept your offer."

I quickly put my hands together in a praying gesture and cautiously reached for the lid of the lunch box.
I felt as though I was about to touch a precious gem... I was incredibly tense.
When I finally mustered the courage to open the lid of my lunch box, a wonderful aroma wafted out.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Uwah, that looks delicious...!"

This wasn't mere flattery. It was a lunch box that really reflected Senpai, with each ingredient thoughtfully packed in.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I hope it suits your taste…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Thank you so much...!"

I took a bite of the rolled omelet. It wasn't too thin, and the saltiness that filled my mouth felt just right.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Delicious...! So fluffy...!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Really? I'm glad."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Senpai, you're so good at cooking...!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"R-really? I'm not sure if I'm good at it, but I enjoy doing it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wow…"

He's good-looking, intelligent, and has a great personality. And on top of that, he's a great cook!
He can literally do anything. I think his future wife might feel like she is not up to his standard.
He seems more feminine than me…
...I mean, it's not like I'm going to marry him.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Let's get started."

Senpai also put his hands in a praying gesture and then opened the lid of the other lunch box.
I absentmindedly glanced through the contents…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"?!"

I was startled.
His lunch box was beautifully crafted, and you could tell at a glance that a lot of effort had gone into making it.
Even side dishes didn't feel like a rushed afterthought; every part of the meal had been made with great care.
I'd never seen anything of this quality in a student's lunch box.
As I stared intently at his meal, Senpai scratched his cheek, looking somewhat apologetic.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"This lunch looks much more delicious, doesn't it?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh...?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I'd love to share it with you, but I can't, sorry... It was made for me by somebody else…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Aah, no, of course you ought to eat it, Senpai...!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I feel kind of bad... I'm the one who's getting the better deal here."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, don't worry about it! The lunch box you gave is delicious, I'm really grateful to have it at all...!"

Actually, something else was bothering me.
Senpai said that it was made by someone else… I wondered who that person might be.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um... If you don't mind me asking, who made this for you?"

I asked him this out of simple curiosity. Then Senpai's expression became softer than I had ever seen it.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"My childhood friend."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh…"

Senpai... I didn't know you had a childhood friend…
Oh no... I have a bad feeling about this… Because judging by this lunch box…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Is that friend... a girl?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"That's right. We're the same age. Our houses are next door to each other."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"O-ooh..."

If this were a story... with a setup like this, she'd be the main heroine…
Unless something goes wrong, the road ahead of them seems to lead directly to marriage.
Actually, maybe they're already…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Senpai... Is she your girlfriend?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Huh?! No, you're wrong! We're just friends...!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I-I see…"

That's good... I feel a little relieved now…
Although, judging by his reaction... Maybe he is not really against the idea…
I bet his childhood friend likes him back, too.
Otherwise she wouldn't have put this much effort into making a lunch box for him…

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"*Sigh*..."

Despite myself, I let out a sigh.
I can't win against his childhood friend. And now, having the whole school treat us like a couple felt absurd.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Anesaki-san... are you okay?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, yes, I'm fine!"

I pulled myself together and started eating the omelet again.
Senpai's chopsticks hovered over the lunch box for a moment, but he soon also picked up a piece of rolled omelet.
Then he went still, as though reluctant to eat it.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"..."

Senpai took a bite of the rolled omelet.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"..."

...? ...What's going on?
The expression on his face was strained. Even his chewing looked unnatural.
Did it taste bad...? ...No, this immaculate lunch box couldn't possibly be of poor quality…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Senpai... Do you hate rolled omelettes?"

I waited until he'd finished eating before asking.
Senpai took a sip of his tea and smiled sheepishly.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Er... Did I look weird?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"A little bit."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Hahaha... I don't actually hate rolled omelettes. But I don't like them sweet."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, is that so?"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Yes, I'm really not a fan of sweets… I prefer savory omelettes over sugary ones…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, that makes sense, the omelet in your lunch box was salty too."

Did the childhood friend not know that...? Surprising.

Okay, I need to make sure to remember that.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Oh, by the way, if you don't like something in the lunch box, don't force yourself to eat it. Just leave it there."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, no, I can't do that! I'll eat it all! I really want to! It's really delicious!"

I took a piece of blanched spinach and shoved it into my mouth with all my might.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Guh!!!"

It got stuck in my throat...!

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Wai... Are you okay?! Here's some tea! Drink it!"

I took the tea from Senpai and quickly gulped it down.
P-phew... I thought I was going to die…

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Are you feeling better now...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Y-yes... it was delicious... very much so…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"..."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"...Pfft… Ahahahaha!"

Senpai burst out laughing again.
...Uh... Wh-what's going on...? I don't know how to react…

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Really... Anesaki-san, watching you is so entertaining sometimes."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Uh…"

"Entertaining"...? I wondered what that meant…
It didn't seem like he meant it in a bad way. But I was aiming for an elegant beauty image, so I was not sure whether I should be happy about being called that.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Ah, I meant this as a compliment, of course."

He probably noticed that I was uneasy and was trying to smooth things over.

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I like that about you, Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Mmf?!"

A meatball got stuck in my throat...!

**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Whoa?! T-tea!!!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...*Cough*... *Cough*..."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"A-are you okay...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"...Y-yes, please forgive me... Again."

Man... that surprised me…
He said that he liked me…
I know that he didn't mean anything special, but it still made me genuinely happy.
I think now it's safe to assume that he likes me at least a little bit…
I'm bothered by the existence of the childhood friend, but I can still indulge in this little dream a bit longer, right...?

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Thank you for the meal. It was so delicious...!"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"I'm glad you liked it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'll wash the lunch box and return it to you."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Huh? No, it's fine. You don't have to do it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"But I would feel bad otherwise…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"No, don't worry, I'll be using that lunch box again tomorrow anyway."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah, so you will need it back today."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Right. So just give it back to me as is."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm sorry... I'll make it up to you."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"No, don't worry about it."

Well, regardless of what he says, I still want to. This is one of those moments when a heroine ought to be raising her love interest's affection level.

The best way to pay back for a lunch box is to make one in return, right? One day I'll make a perfect lunch box for Senpai.
My goal is to make a lunch box like the one his childhood friend made. No, I'll make one that surpasses hers...!
I'm sure that if I manage to do it I will get Senpai's smiling CG as a reward.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hehe…"
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Um... Anesaki-san...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah!"

...I've got to keep my imagination in check…
*(Go to the next chapter.)*

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## Decline (Shun)

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, I'm good."

If I had to borrow money, I'd rather get it from somewhere else.

**Miho Orikasa**
"You sure?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yep. I'll be gone for a little while."

I left the classroom and headed towards the first-year classroom building.
As I walked through the halls, I noticed a few students glancing in my direction.
It seemed that "the brilliant, beautiful vice president" was just as popular among her underclassmen.
I kept a smile on my face for everyone I passed until I finally reached the door of the classroom I was looking for.
I wondered if Shun was inside.
I quietly peeked into the classroom.
A small crowd had gathered at the back of the room.
And at the centre of it stood… uh-huh, Shun himself, just as I thought.
He appeared to be quite popular with his classmates.
The group sounded pretty excited… It was pretty difficult to approach them.
While I hesitated, unsure of what to do, someone suddenly tapped me on the shoulder.

**???**
"Excuse me."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Uh…?"

I turned around and found myself facing an unfamiliar male student.
From his uniform, I could tell he was a first-year. Maybe he was in Shun's class.

**???**
"You're Shun's sister, aren't you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um… Yes… that's right."
**???**
"Do you need something from him?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, I need his help."
**???**
"Should I call him over for you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah… if it's not too much trouble?"
**???**
"Sure."

The boy smiled and called out towards the back of the classroom.

**???**
"Shun, your sister is here."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh? Sis?"

The moment Shun turned toward me, I immediately felt the eyes of everyone in the classroom fall on me.

**Female student**
"Ohhh. Shun's sister?"
**Female student**
"Wow, she's pretty."
**Male student**
"Lucky!"

…and that went on for a while.
I couldn't help but smile to myself when I realized that Shun was as popular as I was.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh…? What happened?"

Shun stepped into the hallway, looking genuinely concerned.
I straightened my posture and put on the dignified demeanor of an older sister.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun, you don't happen to have a lunch box today, do you?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"What? Of course not. How could I have a lunch box when you overs—"

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

I gave him a silent command to stop talking, and he fell quiet, only muttering something under his breath.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You're going to buy something instead, right?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Hm, well, I guess so."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Then isn't it about time you did that?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"It is."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Then could you go and buy something for me too?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh? No way!"

I knew he wouldn't make this easy.
If we were alone, I would have kicked him in the butt and made him go buy it...
But with his classmates watching, I had to handle this calmly.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Then maybe we should go together?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Huh? Why? I can just go there myself."

Damn it… This guy just wasn't cooperating at all.
I stepped away from the classroom for a moment and motioned for Shun to come closer.

**Shun Anesaki**
"? What?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Listen..."

I leaned in toward Shun's ear.

**Shun Anesaki**
"?!"

Shun instinctively jerked back, but I grabbed his tie and pulled him closer. Keeping him there, I lowered my voice and whispered into his ear.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lend me some money…!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh…?"

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Give. Me. Money."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Sis, did you not bring money?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shush, keep it quiet, idiot. …I forgot my wallet."
**Shun Anesaki**
"I distinctly remember asking you if you forgot anything."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I didn't forget any of my school supplies."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Surely forgetting your wallet still counts?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Just give me money."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Man, I guess I have no choice."

Shun started rummaging through his pockets. I quickly grabbed his hand before he could take anything out.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wait, let's go somewhere else."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh? Why?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Everyone's watching us. I don't want people thinking I'm some pathetic girl who has to borrow money from her younger brother."
**Shun Anesaki**
"That's silly."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"As I said…"

I stepped a little away from Shun and put my fake, friendly smile back on.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun, let's go to the school store together."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Okay, understood."

Good.

**???**
"Excuse me."

Suddenly, the male student from earlier called out to me from behind.

**???**
"May I join you?"

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"You don't have your lunch today either?"
**???**
"Yes, so I need to buy something too."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hmm. Well, I don't mind…"

Shun quickly glanced at me.
Well, I don't really mind too.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Are you sure though? Won't I make things awkward?"
**???**
"No, no, not at all."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well, all right then..."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Okay, let's hurry up."

As the three of us started heading toward the school store together, several more boys suddenly came rushing out of Shun's classroom.

**Male student**
"Hey, please let me join too!"
**Male student**
"Me too, me too!"
**Male student**
"Shun, let's have lunch together."
**Shun Anesaki**
"What's gotten into all of you…? You brought your lunch boxes."
**Male student**
"Nope, I forgot mine."
**Male student**
"I'm really craving bread right now."
**Male student**
"I just really want to eat lunch with you, Shun."
**Male students**
"Can we?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"You should be asking her."
**Male students**
"Can we join you?"

The boys asked in perfect unison as they approached me.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Y-yeah… Why not…"

Overwhelmed by their sheer enthusiasm, I had no choice but to agree.
How did things end up like this...?
I'd only planned to buy something from the school store and return straight to my classroom, but somehow, I ended up having lunch with Shun and his friends in the cafeteria.

**Male student**
"Miss! Over here! We found a table!"

One of Shun's friends had claimed a corner of the cafeteria and was being noisy.
I reluctantly made my way there.

**Male student**
"Where would you like to sit?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hm… this place will do."

I took a seat at the very corner of the table.
One of Shun's friends immediately took the seat beside me.
The male student who spoke to me earlier sat directly across from me.
Another boy sat beside him.
And next to him sat a third student with a look of frustration on his face.

**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

Shun arrived a little later, carrying his lunch, and took one of the remaining empty seats with an odd look on his face.
From where I was, it would be difficult to talk to him. I wish he were sitting across from me…

**???**
"Um, should I switch seats with Shun?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh?! Ah, no, of course not!"
**???**
"Okay then. Sorry for the inconvenience."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, it's all right."
**Male student**
"Oshii, let me take your seat."

The student sitting across from me said it in a slightly upset tone.

**Oshii**
"…"

The boy, whom I'd just learned was named Oshii, completely ignored the request and calmly began eating his meal.

**Male student**
"What's going on…? Does Oshii want to make a move too?"
**Male student**
"Yu-kun may look like a serious student, but he is still a guy, after all."
**Shun Anesaki**
"You're both idiots."
**Male student**
"Ohh, Shun-kun's getting mad."
**Male student**
"He is worried that someone will take away his precious sister."
**Male student**
"What a siscon!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

After trembling with frustration for a moment, he began digging into his curry and rice with unusual ferocity.
There, there, little brother, don't get so angry… just bear with it…
After that, I ate my food in silence for some time, since there wasn't really anything to say.
At first, Shun's friends kept praising me at every opportunity, but before I knew it, they got caught up in inside jokes that only made sense within their own friend group.
It's not that I minded it, but for some reason, I couldn't shake the feeling of being out of place.
I should finish eating as quickly as possible and head back to the classroom...
…Then I suddenly felt someone's gaze on me and looked up.

**Yu Oshii**
"I'm sorry, you probably can't follow the conversation."

Oshii-kun smiled apologetically.
This boy has been very considerate toward me. Feeling a little more fond of him, I gently shook my head.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, it's fine, really. Don't worry about me."
**Yu Oshii**
"I'm not very good at talking... I'm sorry I can't come up with anything interesting to discuss."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, I wasn't really contributing to the conversation either... I don't really know how to talk to first-year students."
**Yu Oshii**
"...What do you usually talk about with Shun?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Uh… with Shun…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"I love Lord Wald!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, yeah."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I want to kiss Lord Wald."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Just don't do this to the poor screen."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Can I marry Lord Wald?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Go ahead."

…We were just talking about some silly things like that…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well… For example, about studying…?"

I just made something up. Well, actually, I often helped Shun with his homework, so it wasn't really a lie.

**Yu Oshii**
"Aah…"

Oshii-kun nodded, looking impressed.

**Yu Oshii**
"Well, I didn't expect any less from the top performing student council vice president."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ahaha…"
**Yu Oshii**
"That sounds great. I would love it if you could teach me too."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sure. If there's anything you don't understand, feel free to ask me anytime."
**Yu Oshii**
"Really? Well, in that case, I'll be counting on you."

Oshii-kun respectfully nodded his head. He seems to be a nice person.
As I involuntarily smiled, the male student sitting next to Oshii-kun made a sour face.

**Male student**
"Hey, look. Yu became friends with Miss before any of us even noticed."
**Male student**
"Seriously…? Damn it. No wonder, he is sitting right next to her…"
**Male student**
"But I am sitting next to her too…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

Shun sat there silently, wearing a gloomy expression. But that was nothing unusual for him, so I didn't pay much attention.
I enjoyed the rest of my lunch while having small talk with Oshii-kun.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well then, I'll head back to the second-year classroom now."
**Make student**
"Of course. See you!"
**Male student**
"Let's have lunch together again sometime!"
**Male student**
"Shun! Let's eat together again sometime!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"That makes no sense, we already eat together all the time."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ahaha... See you later."
**Yu Oshii**
"Excuse me."

Suddenly, Oshii-kun called out to me.

**Yu Oshii**
"Thank you for today. I had a great time."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"The pleasure is all mine. Thank you for being so considerate."
**Yu Oshii**
"No, don't mention it. I hope we get to have lunch together again if the opportunity arises."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, see you."

As I waved to Oshii-kun, I felt an intense gaze from the corner of my eye.

**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

Shun was still looking at me with a sullen expression. He looked like he was in an even worse mood than before.
If we were alone, I would tease him by saying something like, "Are you jealous? You're such a siscon," but I couldn't be my usual playful self around his classmates.
So I just ignored him, turned around on my heel and headed back to the classroom.

# Chapter 9: Top student's duty

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Stand up. Bow."
**Teacher**
"Goodbye."

**Students**
"Goodbye."

The classes were finally over.
I'd been on edge all day because of the whole Kuraguchi-kun situation.
I didn't have a student council meeting that day, so I could just head straight home and cuddle with Lord Wald…
I picked up my bag and stood up from my seat.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Excuse me, Anesaki-san."

…Here it is.
He called my name much louder than he did at lunch.
I wonder what he wants…If he is planning to talk about our past, I have no interest in hearing him out.
As I hesitated, unsure whether to reply, the person sitting in front of me turned around at just the right moment.

**Female student**
"Anesaki-san, are you busy today? I'd really appreciate your help with a few questions."
**Male student**
"Me too, me too."
**Male student**
"Me too, please."

As usual, people started gathering around me.
Any other day this would annoy me, but this time, I actually felt relieved.
Thank you, guys… That being said, this is still too much of a hassle. I'm going home.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sorry… I don't have a student council meeting today, but unfortunately, my family needs my help."
**Female student**
"Ahhh. That's a shame."
**Male student**
"I see."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sorry, maybe next time."

I waved to everyone and quickly left the classroom.

**Homeroom teacher**
"Anesaki-san."

This time, I was stopped by a teacher.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Yes?"
**Homeroom teacher**
"Would you mind taking these materials to the year-level coordinator? I've got something else I need to do right now."

No, sorry.
That was what I wanted to say. But I needed to keep myself in the teachers' good graces.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Okay, sure."

So I took the materials with a smile on my face.
*Sigh*… What a pain. This was the downside of always playing the role of a model student.

*Image:*
Sign above the door: "Stay the course"
Books at the front: Guides for chemistry teachers

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Excuse me."
**Year-level coordinator**
"Oh, Anesaki-san? Hello."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hello, sir. I've brought the documents."
**Year-level coordinator**
"Ah, thanks."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I will be going then."
**Year-level coordinator**
"Ah, Anesaki-san, wait a moment please."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes?"
**Year-level coordinator**
"Could you make copies of this for me?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um… Yes, of course."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I've made the copies."
**Year-level coordinator**
"Thank you, you can leave them here."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sure. I'll be going then."
**Teacher**
"Ah, Anesaki-san."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes?"
**Teacher**
"Could you please take this to my desk in the staff room?"

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Sure."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Excuse me."
**Teacher**
"Oh? Anesaki-san, are you running an errand?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes, that's right."
**Teacher**
"Ahaha, what a good kid."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Not at all. I will take my leave then."
**Teacher**
"Oh, can I ask you to run an errand for me too?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Um…"
**Teacher**
"I'd like you to return this book to the library."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"
**Teacher**
"…So?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Of course."

.....
Damn iiiit!!!
What the heck?! What am I, your errand girl?
Go return that book yourself, you stupid idiot!
I'm going to finish this errand as quickly as possible, rush home, and jump into Lord Wald's arms!
Though I was raging inside, I put on a perfectly calm and composed face and headed to the library.
There was no one in sight.
I relaxed and made my way over to the bookshelf to return the book the teacher had entrusted to me.
Let's see... C39... C—

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Ah…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Gah!"

I let out an uncouth sound that surprised even me. I had a feeling my face was frozen in an awful grimace, and it didn't look like it would return to normal anytime soon.
Why is Kuraguchi-kun here…? Could it be that I'd unknowingly triggered a flag? Am I entering Kuraguchi-kun's route?

I don't want to…! I'm certain his route will lead me straight to a bad ending where my school life falls apart.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Hello..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Hey."

We exchanged nods and I shoved the book I was holding back where it belonged.
And now I needed to leave the scene as quickly as possible.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Excuse me."

…As I thought, he stopped me.
Kuraguchi-kun was holding a book (probably a light novel) in one of his hands.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Are there any librarians or library committee members around...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…We have library committee members, but they're most likely slacking off. Our students don't really use the library."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Oh, really? I wanted to borrow a book... How can I do that?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

I am a kind and friendly student council member, of course I should help him…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Follow me."

I beckoned Kuraguchi-kun over and led him to the library counter.
I took a new library card from the drawer and handed it to him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Write your name on this card, along with the title of the book you want to borrow. There's an example on the sign over there, so just follow that."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Okay, understood."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Also… can I see that book for a moment?"

I lowered my gaze to the book Kuraguchi-kun was holding.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Uh… Yeah… sure."

Kuraguchi-kun hesitated for a moment before handing me the book.
It was probably a light novel…
When I looked at the cover, my heart skipped a beat.
Ah, the memories... This was a series I used to be really into. Come to think of it, I'd started reading it after Ayumu-kun had lent it to me.
I remember how excited we used to get when talking about our thoughts on the books.
Looking back, we were pretty embarrassing back then, but it was fun…

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…Anesaki-san?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Oh, sorry. Um... there's a card tucked inside the book cover, so please write your name on it."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Understood."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Once you've filled them out, put both cards in this case. When you finish reading it, just put the book in the return box over there."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Can I do all of this myself?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes. Or you can ask one of the library committee members to handle it when they're around, but that probably won't be very often."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I see. I'll remember that."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"That's basically all there is to it. Do you have any other questions?"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"No, not really."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Good. Then I'll be going, okay?"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Yes, thank you, Nozomi-chan."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You're welcome. See you, Ayumu—"

…Oh.
The moment I stopped speaking, I felt a light grip on my wrist.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I knew it!"

The distance between us suddenly shrank.
Kuraguchi-kun's lips curved upward.
…Yes, he was still the Ayumu-kun I knew.
Dazed, I lifted my gaze to the familiar smile before me.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**

"It's you, Nozomi-chan. …Am I right?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

I couldn't find the right words right away.
A mix of nostalgia, surprise, and anxiety welled up inside me at the same time, clouding my judgment.
After a long silence, I cautiously started speaking.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes… I am Nozomi. So what of it?"

For now, I decided to play dumb. Even after he'd figured everything out, I wasn't about to treat Kuraguchi-kun the way I used to.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…Do you remember me?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Hm?"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"We used to hang out a lot when we were in middle school."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Are you sure…?"

Kuraguchi-kun made a sad face.
A lingering sense of guilt gnawed at my heart.
Despite whatever I told myself, it still felt wrong to treat Kuraguchi-kun like a stranger.
We used to be really good friends.
...Or rather, back then, Kuraguchi-kun was the only person I could call a friend.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I didn't even recognize you at first."

That's not surprising.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"But when you called me by my name this morning, I thought, 'Wait, could it be…?' "
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I wanted to make sure, but I just couldn't find the right moment."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I've been watching you all day and started to doubt myself…"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"But after talking to you just now, I realized, 'Ah, it really is you, Nozomi-chan.' "
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"You seemed different at first, but you haven't changed at all."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"It's nice to see you again, Nozomi-chan."
**Nozomi Anesaki**

"…"

As I listened to Kuraguchi-kun, a strange, inexplicable emotion welled up inside me.
Uneasiness. Irritation. That carefree smile of his even made me feel something close to hatred.
"Haven't changed at all," you say?
You've got to be kidding me. What does he even know?
Things are different now.
I've studied fashion and learned how to carry myself in a way that makes people like me.
Yes, it drains me day by day, but now everyone loves me.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Nozomi-chan, do you remember me?"

Kuraguchi-kun innocently asked me the question.
I quietly clenched my fists.
I wasn't about to throw away everything I'd built up to this point.
It is time to leave Kuraguchi-kun, who hasn't changed since back then, behind.

**Options:**
(1) Stay away from me.
(2) I don't remember you.

---

# Stay away from me.

*If you're on Ayumu's route, it will give you a happy ending. Otherwise, this option won't be made available.*

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Stay away from me."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Huh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I do remember you, Ayumu-kun. We used to hang out a lot back in the day."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"I knew it!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"But… I'm sorry. We can't be close like we used to be."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Huh…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm different now."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm sorry, but… please stay away from me."

I snapped the flag right at the base.
Kuraguchi-kun didn't say a word. He just stared at me. I could tell that he was very shocked.
I'm a terrible person. If anyone found out who the real "Nozomi Anesaki" was, they'd be disillusioned very quickly.
But it didn't matter. I didn't need to pretend to be someone I wasn't to Kuraguchi-kun.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"So… could you let go of my hand?"

The hand gripping my wrist loosened and slipped away, releasing me without me having to pull it free.
I turned my back on Kuraguchi-kun and quickly left the library.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"

As I walked down the corridor, a feeling of regret gradually began to wash over me.
I thought about how I would feel if I were in his place. I realized it must have hurt him deeply.
*(Go to "Conclusion")*

---

## I don't remember you.

*If you're on Ayumu's route, it will give you a normal ending. Otherwise, you automatically get it if you are on another LI's route.*

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Sorry, I don't remember you."

I decided to deny it to the very end. I will keep pretending we're complete strangers, as though our past had never happened.

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Really...? You don't remember anything at all?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Well… actually, I think you've mistaken me for someone else."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Huh…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I wasn't really close with boys in middle school."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I think it's just a coincidence that we have the same name."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"But… didn't you used to be Nozomi Kimura-chan?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…No, I've always been Nozomi Anesaki."

**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Even back then…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Always."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…"

Kuraguchi-kun fell silent, looking unconvinced. I gently shook his hand off my wrist.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"That's why I am not the Nozomi-chan you used to know."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…I see… But… Hmm…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Sorry?"
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"Huh? Ah, no… I should be the one apologizing. Sorry. I ended up going on about stuff that probably didn't make any sense to you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Don't worry about it. I will be going home then."
**Ayumu Kuraguchi**
"…Yeah. Thanks for everything today."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No worries. Goodbye."

…Phew. I think I pulled it off… right?
But I don't feel satisfied at all.
He used to be a very dear friend of mine, yet I cut ties with him so easily. I'm a selfish and heartless girl.
*(Go to "Conclusion")*

---

## Conclusion

…No, If I let it bother me, it would be a lose-lose situation.
This was the only way to protect my blissful school life.

# Chapter 10: Top student's melancholy

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm home…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Oh, welcome back. You took your time today."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Mm."
**Shun Anesaki**
"? Did something happen?"

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"No, why?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Hm?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Call me when dinner's ready."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Uh-huh."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"*Sigh*…"

I collapsed onto my bed. I wasn't feeling particularly great.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I should play a game…"

At times like this, Lord Wald is the best source of comfort.

**Wald**
"Oh, Nozomi, what's wrong? You look so pale."
**Nozomi**
"Do I…?"
**Wald**
"This frown is ruining your beautiful face. Come on, smile like you always do."
**Nozomi**
"…"
**Wald**
"...Is something wrong?"
**Nozomi**
"I have committed a sin..."
**Wald**
"…What sin?"
**Nozomi**
"I have betrayed God… I'm such a vile person."
**Wald**
"Nozomi... Look up."
**Nozomi**
"Lord Wald…?"
**Wald**
"You shouldn't call yourself 'vile.' "
**Nozomi**
"But I…!"
**Wald**
"You're beautiful."
**Nozomi**
"That's not true! I've done something unforgivable!!!"
**Wald**
"A person who can admit their own sins cannot be truly vile, can they?"

**Nozomi**
"…Lord Wald, don't you hate me for it?"
**Wald**
"Haha, what a silly question, Nozomi. I love you no matter what."
**Nozomi**
"...Lord Wald!!!"
**Wald**
"Nozomi…!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Haha."

A dry laugh escaped my lips.
For some reason, I wasn't at all immersed in the game, so I switched off the console without bothering to save.
The reflection of my face on the now completely black screen resembled a Noh mask.
Gross.
Feeling even more exhausted, I collapsed face down onto the bed.
I wish I could be an otome game heroine...
She's cute, has a great personality, and is loved by everyone without having to do anything...
If I could be like that, I wouldn't have to worry about anything, and life would truly be on easy mode.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Sis?"

I heard Shun's voice from beyond the door.
I was too lazy to even lift my head, so I remained face down and uttered in a muffled voice.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…What?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"

He didn't respond. Maybe he didn't hear me.
Oh well, I didn't feel like shouting, so I decided to ignore him.
…But then the door opened.
He just barged in without asking.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You have to warn people before you come in."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Oh, so you're awake."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I am."
**Shun Anesaki**
"I thought you were sleeping."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"People who barge into someone's room while they're sleeping are the worst."

**Shun Anesaki**
"Why are you so angry?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm not? …So, did you need something?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I came to call you because dinner's ready."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh? Already?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Because it's instant ramen."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wow, someone is cutting corners."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Well, you didn't make lunch for me today either, so I think that's only fair."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…You're right, I'll give you that."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Hey, Shun."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hm?"

I rolled over to face him.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…I'm pretty vile, aren't I…?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Right?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"No… I didn't really understand your question."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Just answer me."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Hm…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Am I vile?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Well, you're certainly no saint."

…Tch. Well, what else did I expect from Shun? He is absolutely tactless, nothing like Lord Wald.
But…
For some reason, I felt all the tension leave me, and I couldn't help but smile.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Hehehehe."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Woah, that's gross."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You're the worst."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Are you feeling better?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Well, yeah."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Good."

He smiled at me. It's been a while since I last saw that expression.
But…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I can do without Shun's CG."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huuh…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm not into the younger-brother archetype, you know."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah, okay."
*(Go to "Night time".)*

---

*This scene triggers If you had lunch with Shun.*

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"By the way, you were in a terrible mood during lunch."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh? …Ah, don't worry about it."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Were you jealous because Oshii-kun and I got along?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"What? Absolutely not."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hehehe, you're such a siscon."
**Shun Anesaki**
"You're being ridiculous."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Jokes aside… Here, take it."

I handed Shun 300 yen.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Huh? What's that for?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm giving you back the money I owed you for lunch today. I hope it will cheer you up."

**Shun Anesaki**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"You're an idiot."

Shun suddenly snorted. It looked like he was no longer upset.
*(Go to "Night time".)*

---

## Night time

Before I knew it, it was already 11 pm.
I finished my game and crawled into bed.

---

## Shun & Hozumi

I have student council duty tomorrow, so I'll be able to see Hoshina-senpai in the morning.
I wanted to give myself plenty of time to get ready, so I needed to go to bed early and make sure I didn't oversleep.
When I closed my eyes, I could faintly hear sounds coming from the other side of the wall.
Shun was still awake.
Judging by the sounds, Shun would probably sleep until the very last moment again tomorrow morning. I couldn't help but envy his freedom.

---

## Ayumu

When I closed my eyes, Kuraguchi-kun's face came to mind.
I couldn't seem to stop thinking about what happened in the library.
Tomorrow… How should I face him?
I guess I'll just act like nothing happened and keep pretending I don't know him.
*Sigh*… I was the one who cut him off, so why do I feel so bad about it...?

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## Fail state

When I closed my eyes, Lord Wald's gentle smile came to mind.
The lingering emotions from the ending I'd just seen filled my heart.
Ah… Why is Lord Wald so wonderful…?
Why does Lord Wald have to exist only in 2D...?
I really can't deal with this 3D world...
Ah... I want to go to the world of WataPuri...
.....
.....

# Chapter 11: Daily routine

5 AM. I woke up to the sound of my alarm.
I have to leave for school earlier than usual today because of my student council duty.
Fighting the urge to sleep a little longer, I quickly got out of bed.
For the record, I always get up at this hour, regardless of whether I have student council duty.
First thing first, I washed my face. Then I spent ten minutes doing various facial exercises, followed by a five-minute facial massage.
After that, I changed into my uniform and put on a face mask.
While the mask was on, I brushed my hair. Once I took it off, I put on sunscreen and dusted my face with loose powder.
I also curled my eyelashes and applied two coats of mascara. But my face still looked a little dull, so I finished with a light touch of eyeliner.
Then, after thoroughly blow-drying my hair until it was perfectly smooth and straight, I carefully tied it into twintails.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Done!"

I'm ready now. Hehe, and I look pretty good today.
I headed to the kitchen to prepare lunch boxes. Since Shun handles dinner, making lunch is part of my daily routine.
I also made a simple breakfast while I was at it.
I was taking my time enjoying my morning when I suddenly noticed it was already 7:30.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Shun!"

I opened the door without knocking.
Then I barged into his room and stopped beside his bed.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wake up!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"It's 7:30! You'll be late!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Mmm..."

Shun squirmed a little bit.
I watched him silently as he stopped moving again.
Oh dear... Every morning is the same. I really should do something about Shun's terrible sleeping habits.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Wake. Up. This. Instant. Young. Man!"

I tore the blanket off him with great force.
He finally slightly opened his eyes.

**Shun Anesaki**
"...What time is it now...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"7:30."
**Shun Anesaki**
"Then... I can sleep for another 15 minutes..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You can't!"

I grabbed him by the shoulders and rocked him back and forth.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You need to wake up!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Mmm..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I said wake up!"

I lightly slapped his cheek.
He glanced at me with annoyance.

**Shun Anesaki**
"What...? What are you doing...?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm heading to school."
**Shun Anesaki**
"I see... Have a good day..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Hey!"

This time, I slapped the cheek on his sleepy face twice.

**Shun Anesaki**
"What the hell...!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Do my outfit check!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Huuh...?"

I straightened up and waited for his judgement as he frowned at me. I couldn't leave the house with peace of mind until I completed this daily routine.

**Nozomi Anesaki**

"Am I cute?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Yeah... very cute..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"..."
**Shun Anesaki**
"..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"..."
**Shun Anesaki**
"...Mhm."

...This is no good.
I set Shun's alarm clock for 15 minutes later and quietly left the room.
Our student council's morning duty is a monthly conduct check. We stand at the school gate in the morning and make sure students are following the school's rules.
This involves greeting students as they arrive and checking their appearance. Two student council members are assigned to the duty each month.
I left my things in the classroom and headed to the gate. Hoshina-senpai was already waiting for me there.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Good morning, Senpai."
**Mizuho Hoshina**
"Morning, Anesaki-san. Let's do our best today too."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Yes!"

Ah, Hoshina-senpai is as dreamy as ever. That realization made me a little happy. I put on my armband and turned to face the students.

# Normal end: 2D Forever

**Wald**
"Nozomi."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald... I'm so happy to see you."
**Wald**
"Nozomi... I have something important to tell you today."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wh-what is it…?"
**Wald**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald...? Why do you look so sad...?"
**Wald**
"I came to say goodbye to you."

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Huh?"
**Wald**
"It's time for you to start looking toward the outside world."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wh-what does that mean...?"
**Wald**
"You should forget about me and spend your life with someone who will treasure you more than I can."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wh-what are you even saying?! I can't be with anyone but you, Lord Wald…!"
**Wald**
"Is that really true?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh…?"
**Wald**
"Close your eyes and think back."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…H-Hoshina-senpai…?"
**Wald**
"Isn't he your ideal man?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Indeed… Senpai is very dreamy…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"But… he won't accept me like you do, Lord Wald…"
**Wald**
"Then what about him? He is a dear friend who accepts you, isn't he?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ayumu-kun… Yes, he's a very important friend to me. But I can't be with him."
**Wald**
"Why is that?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Because I don't have the courage to break the status quo."
**Wald**
"Then... What about him? He understands you and looks out for you, doesn't he?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Not happening."
**Wald**
"Uh?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I'm not into the younger-brother archetype."
**Wald**
"I-I see…"
**Wald**
"There are still so many people you haven't met yet."
**Wald**

"The world is vast. There are more people who care about you than you realize."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I've already told you... you're the only one who would ever treat me this well, Lord Wald..."
**Wald**
"But… you'll forget about me someday, won't you?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh…"
**Wald**
"I am certain of it. Your infatuations never last even a year..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh?! No, no, that's not true… uh… I think…?"
**Wald**
"I am, after all, a 2D being. I cannot live in the same world as you."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald…"
**Wald**
"But even if you forget me, I will forever remember you."
**Wald**
"I will keep calling your name. I will keep watching over you."
**Wald**
"If you ever find yourself thinking about me, I'll always be ready to accept you."
**Wald**
"So we can part ways with peace of mind."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald…!"
**Wald**
"…Farewell."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wait, Lord Wald?! Lord Wald!!!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"P-please wait!!! Don't go!!!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Lord Wald!!! LORD WALD!!!"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Noooo!!! Wait a—"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Whoa?!"

……
……

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Huh? …Shun?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Y-yeah…"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"What are you doing…?"
**Shun Anesaki**

"No, I think I should be asking you this…"

I could feel Shun's breath on my ear as he muttered it softly.
I let that sink in for a few seconds.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"WAAAH!!!"

Shun was clinging tightly to me until I pushed him away.
Why? Why is Shun in my room?
Wait, what time is it now? What's going on here?

**Shun Anesaki**
"Ow… What the heck are you doing?!"

Shun stood up, clearly annoyed.
I still didn't understand what was going on, so I ignored him and shifted my gaze around the room.
…It's bright. Is it morning?
Hmm, morning means…

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"…Shun… What time is it…?"
**Shun Anesaki**
"8 AM."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Aaaaah!!!"

I jumped out of bed in panic and flung the closet doors open.
I can't believe I overslept two days in a row…! On top of that, I needed to be at school early for my student council duty…!

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Noo… It's already too late now!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I did wake you up properly, you know."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"You should have done so earlier!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"How was I supposed to know? And also… well…"

Shun stammered, looking slightly uncomfortable.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Did something happen…?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh? What do you mean?"
**Shun Anesaki**

"Well, you were crying when I tried to wake you up earlier..."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Huh… Really?"

I peered into the mirror on the closet door. There were indeed faint traces of tears around my eyes.

**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Ah… This must be… due to my nightmare…"
**Shun Anesaki**
"What was it about?"
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"I dreamed that Lord Wald rejected me..."
**Shun Anesaki**
"…Huuh?"

His expression immediately softened, as though he'd suddenly decided it wasn't worth worrying about.

**Shun Anesaki**
"Really…? That's all there was to it? I was worried for nothing."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"What do you mean, 'for nothing'? This hurt me deeply!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"Uh-huh. Ahh… it's morning, and I'm already exhausted. Well, I'm heading to school now."
**Nozomi Anesaki**
"Wait, what?! No, you're not! Wait for me!!!"
**Shun Anesaki**
"I'll tell Prez you overslept. See ya."

He said it matter-of-factly and left the room before I could stop him.
So heartless… Lord Wald would have waited for me.
The 3D world really is unforgiving…

**Wald**
"The world is vast. There are more people who care about you than you realize."

That's what Lord Wald told me, but I wonder if it's really true.
Until I meet someone like that, I suppose I'll just keep retreating into the world of fiction.